



The 13th-century Iona Abbey (pictured) was built on the site of the original monastery founded by St. Columba when he arrived on Iona in 563.

MEROVINGIAN FRANCIA (FRANCE) HAD BEEN DIVIDED into separate kingdoms on the death of Clovis in 511 (see 501–526). Despite this, Frankish power continued to grow. By 558, **Chlothar I** (511–61), who ruled the area of Francia around Soissons, had absorbed the Rheims kingdom and the region around Paris after their rulers died. This left Chlothar as the **sole Merovingian ruler of Francia** for three years, until his death in 561. Francia was once again divided, with Charibert I receiving Paris, Guntram getting Orléans, Sigibert Rheims, and Chilperic Soissons. It was not until 613 that the Frankish kingdom was reunited under **Chlothar II** (r. 613–29).

Ajanta cave art

The *Ajanta caves*, a Buddhist holy site in Maharashtra, India, experienced a second major phase of use during the 6th century.

Ireland had been converted to Christianity by **Patrick** (d. 461) in the mid-5th century and a strong **monastic tradition** took hold there. From the 6th century, Irish monks began conducting missions abroad. In 563, **Columba** (c. 520–97) set up the **abbey of Iona** on an island off Scotland's western coast. Iona became a center of Irish-influenced monasticism, which extended into northern England, Scotland, and Francia with the foundation of the monastic center at Luxeuil in 590.

The **Gupta Empire fell apart** after the reign of Vishnugupta (r. 540–50); and northern India split into a number of **regional kingdoms**. A minor branch of the Guptas ruled Magadha, but they were swept aside by the Maukharis of Kanauj. The region fell to the Vardhana king **Harsha**, who established an empire in the early 7th century.

“WHEN **JUSTIN** HAD HEARD THESE EVENTS... HE HAD **NO HEALTHY OR SANE THOUGHTS... HE FELL INTO A MENTAL DISORDER AND MADNESS** AND AFTERWARD HAD **NO UNDERSTANDING OF EVENTS.**”

Evagrius Scholasticus, scholar and aide to Gregory of Antioch, on Justin II's reaction on the fall of Dara to the Persians, from *Ecclesiastical History* c. 595

JAPAN'S SOGA FAMILY CAME TO PROMINENCE IN 540, when Soga **no Iname** was made chief minister. **Emperor Bidatsu's death** in 585 led to a succession dispute, from which Iname's grandson **Yomei** emerged successful. The next emperor, **Sushun** (r. 586–93), had a Soga mother, reinforcing the family's dominance. When Sushun was assassinated in 593, he was succeeded by another Soga, Bidatsu's widow **Suiko** (r. 593–628), Suiko's reign saw the start of the **Asuka Enlightenment**, and was a time of great confidence in foreign affairs, state support for Buddhism, and flourishing arts.

In 572, the Byzantine emperor **Justin II** (r. 565–78) went to **war with Persia** after he refused to pay a tribute due under the terms of Justinian's 50-year peace deal (see 527–540). In 573, Persia struck back, invading Syria and taking the

7 THE NUMBER OF YEARS THE “ENDLESS PEACE” OF 532 BETWEEN THE BYZANTINE EMPIRE AND PERSIA LASTED

fortress of Dara. On hearing this, Justin went insane. His wife took power, and had to agree a humiliating peace with Persia.

In 567, the **Lombards**, who had settled in the former Roman province of Pannonia (Hungary), destroyed the Gepids and then, under **Alboin** (reign c. 560–72), moved southwest into Italy, where the Byzantine authorities were too weak to resist them. In 568–69 they **occupied the plain of the Po River** and set up dukes in major cities. By 572, when Pavia fell to them, they had founded duchies as far south as Benevento. Attempted

Byzantine counterattacks in 575 were a disaster. Under **Agilulf** (r. 590–616) the Lombard kingdom consolidated; the Byzantines were limited to small territories around Rome, Naples, and Ravenna.

Under **Khan Bayan** (r.c. 562–82), the **Avars**—nomadic horsemen from the northern Caucasus—exploited the vacuum left by the departure of the Lombards to **carve out a vast territory** around modern Austria. Their conquest of a number of Byzantine towns prompted **Emperor Maurice** (r. 582–602) into a successful campaign to dislodge them.



552 Gao Yang deposes China's last Eastern Wei emperor, starting the Northern Qi dynasty

552 Korean state of Paekche allies with Japan against Silla, its Korean rival

553 Byzantines complete their reconquest of Italy

553 Yu Wenju deposes China's Western Wei ruler, founding the Northern Zhou dynasty

553 Irish missionary Columba begins evangelizing Scotland

553 Justin II becomes Byzantine emperor

558 Chlothar I becomes sole ruler of Francia

562 50-year peace signed between Byzantine emperor Justinian and Chosroes I of Persia

568 Lombards move south from the Danube and invade Italy

c. 570 Sef ibn Dhi Yazan founds the Bornu kingdom of Kanem in Central Africa

570 Persians expel the Askumites from Yemen

573 Frankish kingdom riven by civil war

577 In China, the Northern Zhou are overthrown by Yang Jian, who founds the Sui dynasty

577 Saxons win Battle of Dyrham, completing the conquest of most of southern England

c. 580 Avars establish a state on the Hungarian plain

582 Byzantine emperor Tiberius II surrenders Sirmium (in modern Serbia) to the Avars and pays them tribute

585 Construction of new defensive walls in the north of China